Although we never stopped trying to find them, it was very difficult to pinpoint exactly where a hostage was at any given time. Although we created special commando teams trained for the specific mission of rescuing hostages, we couldn't just storm a building where we believed hostages were held, because of the risk that by the time we got to them, the hostages would be dead. Even a rumor or false newspaper report that we were going to try to rescue them might be fatal.

Our hands were tied in other ways. We couldn't negotiate with kidnappers. That would simply encourage terrorists to take more hostages. And as a nation we placed limits on how far we would go to counter terrorism. A few people within the administration wanted to follow Menachem Begin's slogan of "an eye for an eye" and assassinate leaders of the most bloodthirsty groups that had committed terrorism against the United States and its citizens—but this was a game that America couldn't and didn't play. Early in my administration, I signed an order prohibiting direct or indirect involvement in murder during covert operations. This was one reason why the CIA had difficulty infiltrating terrorist groups—many of which required new members, as a show of loyalty, to assassinate an enemy of the organization.

Often, during our searches for terrorists, as after the marine barracks bombing in Beirut, we collected information that gave our experts reasonable confidence—but not absolute certainty—that they knew where the terrorists were located. I vetoed proposals to attack several of these sites. I just didn't want to take the chance that we'd kill innocents. George Shultz and Cap Weinberger concurred in this position. We also knew, of course, that if we did strike a site where we thought the culpable terrorists were encamped, we might harm the American hostages. Our options were few, and I spent many, many hours late at